

For Franklin, facing up to his obligations would have required a sacrifice in his lifestyle but it was no comparison to the sacrifice in his self-worth and freedom of movement by running away. He could evade responsibility as long as he remained in hiding and never returned to the United States. Maybe in time, Franklin would realize the ultimate sacrifice he had made.

### **Ten Years Is a Long Time**

The reason so many people choose to file a bankruptcy is that they want to have a fresh start. In reality, after the debts are gone, the memory lingers on your credit report for up to ten years. This fact is significant since your credit report is widely accessed. Not only do lenders pull your credit report, but so too do potential employers, life insurance companies, and landlords. Your credit report will be the basis for many decisions that will be made: your approval for a loan; your admittance to an apartment unit; or your getting a job. Your decision to file a bankruptcy should be influenced by the fact that credit reports are so powerful.

Julie received her first credit card when she was eighteen years old. She worked part-time at the mall. The department store she worked for offered employees a 10 percent discount on their purchases. However, they were required to buy them with the store's credit card. Julie added seven other credit cards to her collection by the time she graduated.

She used credit to buy anything and everything she wanted; she never denied herself. Before it seemed possible, she was \$20,000 in debt and, having just graduated, was only making \$24,000 at an entry-level job. Her credit card debt had become more than she could handle, so she decided to file bankruptcy. Among the most common reasons for resorting to a bankruptcy is “over-extended credit.”

